The Fall of the Roman Empire

Between 376 and 382 CE, Rome fell into a series of wars against the Goths known as the Gothic Wars. Emperor Valens lost at the Battle of Adrianople, which triggered the beginning of the Roman Empire's decline. Scholars cannot agree on why the empire fell because there were likely numerous reasons. The historian Edward Gibbon suggests that it was Christianity that caused the fall of this mighty empire because it lacked the morals to support the social customs of the Roman people. Others suggest that the empire was simply stretched too thin to protect itself from outsiders and foreign invasions. Yet another theory is that it couldn't support its citizens due to economic problems. The amount of food available was scarce and the government was not able to effectively collect taxes that were owed by the people. Because of these internal reasons and vicious external raids from the Visigoths, Rome began to deteriorate quickly.

The Western Roman Empire fell on September 4, 476 CE when King Odoacer overthrew Emperor Romulus Augustus. However, various scholars mark the end of the Empire as 480 CE when Julius Nepos died. The Eastern Roman Empire carried on under the name of the Byzantine Empire, which lasted until 1453. Nonetheless, the Roman Empire is known to have influenced many newer civilizations and is one of the greatest empires to exist in history.